A plane rumbled overhead, its cargo of leaflets fluttering down like snowflakes. “Hamas has created a disaster for the residents of the Gaza Strip by opening an unequal war against the state of Israel,” the fliers announced in Arabic. A middle-aged man retrieved one from the branches of a tree and stared uncomprehending at the sloping, curved letters. “I hope that’s not all we’re dropping on them,” he muttered.

A woman leaned on a metal barricade at the military cemetery, watching from a distance as a mother sobbed over her son’s coffin. Next to it was another freshly-dug grave. The man’s father, his black T-shirt torn in keeping with Jewish custom, stood to the side and wept quietly. The woman, a casual acquaintance, was there to show her support. “We should kill a hundred of theirs for every one of ours,” she said.

Just like its political history, Israel’s military history can be cleaved roughly into two halves. There have been thirteen wars since the country was founded in 1948, according to the defense ministry. For the first few decades, these were mostly conventional battles against states: the counterproductive invasion of Sinai in 1956, alongside France and the United Kingdom; the stunning victory in 1967; the near-catastrophe in 1973. The following years brought a change in politics, as the Likud party took power, ending thirty years of Labor dominance, and in war, as Israel invaded Lebanon in 1982 to strike at the Palestine Liberation Organization, which had carried out repeated attacks across the border. The invasion and the main fighting lasted only a few months, but the subsequent occupation would drag on for nearly two decades. It offered a preview of future conflicts in the Middle East: insurgents, proxy militias and suicide bombings, a technique perfected in Lebanon by Hezbollah and other anti-Israeli factions.

That war enjoyed near-unanimous support from Israel’s political class, at least in its earliest days. On 8 June 1982, two days after the invasion, the joint Jewish-Arab Communist party Hadash introduced a no-confidence motion in the Knesset, warning that the government was “leading Israel to the abyss”. The measure was defeated by 94 votes to 3; only the Hadash MKs voted in favor.[21] Herzl Rosenblum, the editor of *Yediot Aharonot*, suggested prosecuting them for treason.

One of his journalists, Amiram Nir, soon coined the phrase *sheket, yorim*: “quiet, we’re shooting”. It was a plea for national unity in the midst of a